

6"x8". Mid-range can be as big as 9"x12" and the top models come in sizes as big as 18"x12". This really comes down to user preference, a smaller surface allows you to work just as one would on a bigger tablet except there isn't much need to zoom in and out constantly. Once a user gets accustomed to a smaller surface then there would be next to no difference in productivity when compared to a person working on a bigger screen. Also smaller screens result in less movement of the arm and subsequently it is less stressful.

With or without display

The bigger models are similar to monitor displays with a touchscreen overlay. The tablet is one huge screen where you can actually see what you are working on, this makes for a much more natural approach and also a much more expensive tablet. Don't be worried about getting a tablet without a display as the tablet is still able to track the stylus over its surface even when the stylus is not making contact so you can figure out where on the screen your hand corresponds to.

Interface

The stylus which we've talked about so far also has buttons on them, and these can be programmable buttons so you can have a delete function or swap a tool in photoshop without having to move all the way to the tool bar. Also normal mouse operations like left-clicking and right-clicking also can be accomplished using a stylus. These buttons are often on the stylus itself or sometimes on the bezel of the tablet.

The tablet itself has a host of programmable buttons, from navigating across the workspace to saving macros, the versatility that a tablet brings is commendable. Most mid-size and large-format tablets are ambidextrous by design i.e. the buttons on one side will be replicated in the exact fashion on the other side. For smaller tablets you can simply flip it about and use it with the other hand.

Pressure sensitivity is another factor to consider. The pressure sensitivity allows you to adjust the thickness or texture or colour on the fly. It feels much more like drawing on paper so the harder you press onto the tablet the thicker a line gets. Tablets come with varying pressure levels, common among which are 256, 512, 1024 and 2048. Basically the higher the pressure level the greater flexibility you can achieve. Don't press too hard though, you don't want to damage your new tablet.